

to the Asian Heart Institute—would have acquired the latest in neuro-surgery innovation.

Technology is spreading to smaller towns as well. Faridabad in Uttar Pradesh, for instance, has always been a sleepy little township despite its proximity to the Capital. "It never had good healthcare

infrastructure," says Dr N.K. Pandey, former head of surgery at Escorts and a Dr B.C. Roy awardee who has just started the Asian Institute of Medical Sciences (AIMS). "There is a huge demand-supply gap," he says. "There is a lack of good infrastructure and quality healthcare services here." AIMS is gearing up as

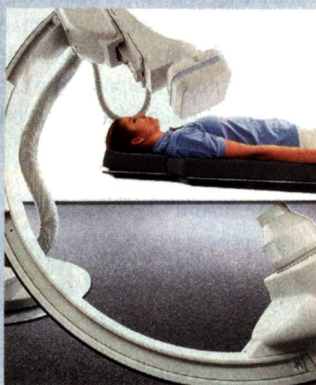
the first superspecialty focusing on cancer care in the area. From the cutting-edge Varian Trilogy machine—one of the very few hospitals in North India with such a device—Pandey has also brought in state-of-the-art systems—PET-CT, MRI, gamma camera, brachytherapy to mammography. His dream is to turn the 350-bed multispecialty tertiary care hospital into a flagship hospital in the field of oncology, minimal invasive surgery, urology and nephrology.

When Dr Nitin Yende of Mumbai floated Vibha Lifesavers in 1996, calls came once in six months. "Today, we handle over 40 calls from across India and the world every month," he says. Older hospitals are tying up with private charter (Air Ambulance India lists up 24 hospitals in NCR, Tops Air Rescue 60 in Mumbai) or aviation companies (Deccan and now Religare Voyages). New hospitals are stealing the thunder by building roof-top helipads. Check out the 19-storied Kokilaben Dhirubhai Ambani Hospital in Mumbai. Not just the metros, they are all across—from the Aditya Birla Memorial Hospital in Pune to the Yashoda Hospital in Secunderabad, Akshaya Apollo in Ahmedabad, Pushpanjali Crosslay in Ghaziabad to Sri Hari Health Foundation in Bhiwani, Haryana.

The moment you walk into a hospital, an unmistakable "hospital smell" engulfs you. But at the Fortis La Femme in Delhi, the flavour of orange blossoms hangs in the air. Expect waiting-room gridlocks. At Bangalore's The Nest, the waiting area looks more like a bank, with wait-for-your-turn counters. Think twiddling your thumbs is your lot as a hospital visitor? At the Oyster & Pearl Hospital in Pune you can spend hours at the cyber café or the massage parlour. Worried about commuting to and from the

Flat Panel Digital Cath Lab

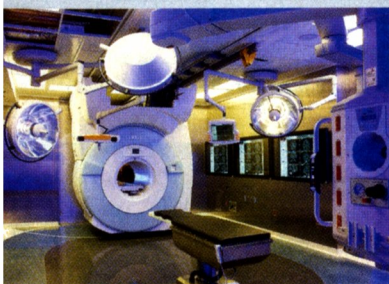
Cath labs have advanced imaging systems that allow doctors to see the workings of the heart and of tiny blood vessels around it. It's all live and doctors really rely on the images to make accurate decisions. The latest flat-panel digital detectors don't just capture distortion-free images but also bring the advantage of lower radiation dose to the patient, clinicians and technologists. A staple in all modern hospitals today.



IMRI & BrainSUITE

The technological breakthrough in magnetic resonance imaging (MRI). IMRI (intraoperative imaging) utilises MRI during surgery to help neurosurgeons determine the success of a procedure by checking real-time images in complicated brain tumour and other brain surgery cases. A separate but fully-integrated operative area is named BrainSUITE. Max Healthcare, Delhi, brought in Asia's first BrainSuite to India. Today, a number of private hospitals—Asian

Heart Institute and Kokilaben Dhirubhai Ambani Hospitals in Mumbai, Medanta-Medicity in Gurgaon, Parvathy Hospital in Chennai—have introduced this fabulously expensive facility.



New Facilities, New Service

What's that buzz overhead? Dr Nishith Chandra scanned the skies. Escorts Heart Institute, Delhi, is no longer the only hospital flying critically-ill patients to and fro. Every hospital worth its salt is dishing out air ambulance services these days. For a moment, he thought about the patient with abnormally fast heartbeat he had flown in from Ludhiana that afternoon. It was nearly touch-and-go, but they had managed to wheel him in to the OR safe and sound. For Chandra, head of air rescues at Escorts, it's all in a day's work. And it's that promise of being saved in the nick of time that's making more and more patients seek air ambulancing despite the cost (Rs 75,000 to Rs 100,000 per hour) and lack of insurance cover.

10 transforming issues for debate:
DTC, GST, Limited Liability Bill,
Land acquisition and others

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